

**‘GONE ON DEBATING:’
COMPETITIVE ACADEMIC DEBATE AS A TOOL OF EMPOWERMENT
Ede Warner and Jon Bruschke**

I've told how debating was a weekly event there, at the Norfolk prison colony. My reading had my mind like steam under pressure. Some way, I had to start telling the white man about himself to his face. I decided I could do this by putting my name down to debate...Once my feet got wet, I was gone on debating. Whichever side of the selected subject was assigned to me, I'd track down and study everything I could find on it. I'd put myself in my opponents' place, and decide how I'd try to win if I had the other side: I'd figure a way to knock down all those points. (Autobiography of Malcolm X, 1964)

Education provides a microscopic paradigm case of broader social inequalities in contemporary America. Kozol (1992) argued almost a decade ago that disenfranchised educational settings lie under-funded and in desolation, and seem especially poor when compared to the quality of pedagogy in private and suburban spheres. One controversy, deemed by some as the “civil rights debate of the nineties” revolves around the issue of tax vouchers, with proponents arguing for increasing the ability of poor students to attend private schools and opponents warning of renewed segregation (Henry, 1999). As these and other issues play themselves out, it is difficult to imagine an America with racial equality so long as educational inequalities manifest themselves along racial lines.

Improving education may require more than traditional programs designed to raise test scores. Impoverished youth are not so much underachievers as they are marginalized and excluded from society. A current assumption is that if under-performing youths could just absorb the content (what has traditionally been called the “curriculum”) of their classes, they will have the skills they need to thrive in society. This essay takes a different view.

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Marginalized students certainly need basic academic skills, but the content of their education must focus always on enriching ways of including students in society. It must emphasize ways to give students not just the tools of the academy, but also the tools of empowerment.

It is doubtful that such an emphasis exists at present. Administrators increasingly focus on what is thought to be the “core” of an education (Wade, 1998). While sports still command a healthy presence in educational institutions, many other “extra-curricular” activities are lost in budgetary shuffles and the panic to improve the basics. This essay will examine the possibility of rekindling academic debate as a true solution to disempowerment and academic defalcation in marginalized schools. The analysis will proceed in two veins. First, the concept of an empowering education is theorized, and the role that debate might play in that education is explored. Our thesis is that debate can transform education and make it a more empowering experience. Second, we will review critical challenges to debate as it is currently practiced and assess how the format of debate might be altered to resist what Tannen (1999) calls the “argument culture.” We will contend that using a method that Matsuda (1987) calls “looking to the bottom” can challenge the assimilationist practices of interscholastic debate and create space for those who best understand how to transform a domination-centered model of debate.

Empowerment and the Role of Debate

With the funding of the Open Society Institute, Urban Debate Leagues (UDLs) have emerged in several different cities. The UDL model seeks to create tournament-centered, policy debate opportunities for under-served high schools. Some have characterized UDL formation as a movement (Baker, 1998). The “movement” moniker suggests an enterprise that seeks to do more than simply offer another extra-curricular option for students, and has as its core concept the belief that debate can transform students’ lives. There is faith in the ability of debate to fundamentally alter a person’s orientation toward education. Given the momentum of the UDL movement, the time is ripe to theorize what is meant by the term “empowerment” and to flesh out what the concept means.

As empowerment is defined, this section will also explore how debate might fit into a truly empowering education. It is important to note at the outset that no particular format of debate is assumed, and the next section will dwell at some length on the different formats that debate might take. The characteristics of tournament-oriented policy debate important for this section are that it is based on student performance, it is competitive, it is

interscholastic, it is time pressured, it is research intensive, and it is dialectical. Of these six characteristics, the term “dialectical” is the word most in need of some additional definition. The dialectical process originally referred to a question-and-answer format between students and teachers and was juxtaposed with a lecturing method of teaching (Infante, Rancer, & Womack, 1990, p. 97), and the word was later ascribed specific technical meanings in the theories of Hegel, Marx, and others. Here we refer to the term in the same fashion as Billig (1987) who uses it to refer to a type of thinking that recognizes both sides of a question, resists absolutist conclusions, demands the thorough questioning of any proposition, and recognizes the value of continually challenging both a thesis and its opposite.

Any reviewer of the literature will have no trouble discerning the wisdom of Jennings' (1992) conclusion that “the term ‘empowerment’ has been used in different, even contradictory ways” (p. 33). For some, the community must be the unit of analysis for empowerment discussions (Walters & Smith, 1999), for others it is the individual (Robinson, 1995), and for some scholars the definition turns on a difference between access to power and the attainment of power itself (Jennings, 1992). Our purpose here is not to break new theoretical ground in definitions of empowerment, but simply to identify a core to the concept. We do not seek a final definition, but simply a definition that includes the core components the concept ought to include. Such a definition will allow us to understand how debate may or may not assist in empowering students.

What, then, does empowerment mean? An understanding of the term must begin in our contemporary social context. The postmodern situation is one in which individuals are more and more dependent upon institutions and bureaucracies, and those bureaucracies have a tendency to insulate themselves from the individuals that they are supposed to serve. As the situation warps itself, the institutions become self-protective and increasingly orient themselves to support the well off while increasingly ignoring the needs of the under-served. The institutions serve the privileged because only the privileged have access to and influence in the institutions. Thus, “one of the most debilitating results of modernization is a feeling of powerlessness in the face of institutions controlled by those whom we do not know and whose values we often do not share” (Galston, 1996, p. 164). Individuals and communities become empowered when they possess “the capacity to change social relations and the ownership, management, and distribution of wealth” (Jennings, 1992, p. 34) in both public and private contexts. Thus, at its most basic level, social policy should focus on “empowering poor people to do the things that the more affluent can already do, aim at

spreading the power around a bit more – and to do so where it matters most, in people’s control over their own lives” (Galston, 1996, p. 164).

We believe that empowerment occurs at both individual and community levels, and that communities are empowered as the individuals in those communities are empowered. Professor Galston (1996) puts forth the view in a powerful way:

Empowerment should be understood...as a multidimensional social possibility. Along one dimension, individuals can be empowered to make personal choices that improve their lives -- choices that may (but need not) require new or stronger associational bonds with others. Along another dimension, communities can be empowered to act in ways that promote the common good as defined collectively by their members. Empowerment, then, is frequently, but not invariably, linked to mediating institutions; it may sometimes be promoted and pursued by individuals through instruments other than these institutions. (pp. 58-69)

Education has long been a key facet of empowerment. Galston (1996) has firmly located education at the center of empowerment: “For many younger Americans, empowerment comes through post-secondary education and advanced training” (p. 60). “Education” is not a static variable, however, and there can be little doubt that the type of education one receives (both its content and its means of transmission) makes a profound difference. What are the characteristics of an empowering education? The possibilities are, of course, multifaceted, and to capture the richness of the concepts we quote Ira Shor (1992) at some length here:

Empowering education invites students to become skilled workers and thinking citizens who are also change agents and social critics. Giroux (1988) described this as educating students “to fight for a quality of life in which all human beings benefit.” He went on to say, “Schools need to be defended, as an important public service that educates students to be critical citizens who can think, challenge, take risks, and believe that their actions will make a difference in the larger society” (214). Further, McLaren (1989) discussed the pedagogy as “the process which students learn to critically appropriate knowledge existing outside their immediate experience in order to broaden their understanding of themselves, the world, and the possibilities for transforming the taken-for-granted assumptions about the way that we live” (186). Banks (1991) defined empowerment in terms of transforming self and society: “A curriculum designed to empower students must be transformative in

nature and help students to develop the knowledge, skills, and values needed to become social critics who can make reflective decisions in effective personal, social, political, and economic action" (131). (pp. 16-17)

Thus, the concept of empowerment goes well beyond the curricular issues and is profoundly impacted by the manner in which education is conducted. In contrast to the traditional, top-down, and lecture-oriented model of educational communication, an empowering classroom must see student growth as "an active, cooperative, and social process" (Shor, 1992, p. 15).

Friere (1993) has taken a similar view and criticized what he deems "narrative sickness" in schools, and taken the stance that empowerment cannot be attained through hierarchical pedagogical practice. So long as "teachers" retain power and are assumed to be superior, and "students" remain powerless and are assumed to be ignorant, students cannot be empowered. Of course, Friere was writing about education in a different context than American high schools, and we do not want to suggest that all traditional assumptions about classroom control are faulty. American teachers are, after all, adults, and the students are typically adolescents, and there is a role that adults need to play in adult/student interactions. However, Friere's point deals with issues more profound than simple classroom discipline and the point is undeniably relevant to debate-as-outreach: It is not possible to develop dynamic, interested, and vibrant learners if the method of education treats students as passive, ignorant vessels unable to develop their own imaginations or recognize their own interests. Students both learn and teach, and instructors both teach and learn. The application of Friere's theories to UDL outreach is that we must not think of ourselves as taking knowledge to an unknowing group of students who we will then assimilate into our current debate practices. Rather, we must work with under-served students and, while sharing our ideas with them, fully expect that they will offer back a plethora of ideas that will in turn transform debate practice as we conceive of it. If this does not occur the UDL experiment may eventually accomplish something else, but it will not have been empowering.

Debate as a Method for Individual Empowerment

Broken down, this compendium of definitions includes at least four requirements for an empowering education. First, students must learn to engage knowledge in a critical way. They must be able to listen carefully to a point of view, examine its strong and weak points in a dialectical way, and then choose for themselves their own beliefs about a subject. They

must “approach received wisdom and the status quo with questions” (Shor, 1992, p. 17) and develop “habits of inquiry and critical curiosity” (Shor, 1992, p. 15). Debate teaches students to become critical thinkers because of its dialectical nature. Students in the habit of questioning the claims of others and thinking through the possible objections to their own claims easily develop the mental faculties needed to become active consumers of information. Rather than simply taking knowledge offered to them at face value, students almost automatically begin thinking through possible objections to any knowledge claim and developing probing questions about it. Consider the recent controversies over whether evolutionism or creationism should be taught in science classes. Some groups would have only creationism taught, some groups would have only evolutionism taught, and some groups would want all perspectives presented to students. Regardless of how policy makers eventually deal with this thorny issue, debate facilitates critical educational outcomes. If only one side of the dispute is taught, debaters will automatically begin to question the point of view advanced by the teacher by virtue of mental habit. If many sides of the issue are taught, debaters will have the intellectual skills necessary to ask the most pointed questions and evaluate the dispute in a mature, informed, and systematic way.

Second, empowered students must be social critics. Essentially, they must apply the same dialectical stance toward the world they live in and the public policies they are asked to live by and participate in enacting. Academic debate facilitates the development of students as social critics because of its policy oriented and research intensive nature. Although learning to think dialectically certainly might have some transferable skill that would allow students to evaluate questions of governance, no such transfer is even necessary. Students are directly debating questions of policy and evaluating the effectiveness, morality, and desirability of different governmental actions along with the possibility of non-governmental alternatives. Because all debates begin with an affirmative indictment of the status quo, all policy debates invoke questions of what the current social order is like and how it can be improved. Even when debating the negative, students may offer “counter-plans” that provide alternative policy arrangements, or philosophical critiques that ask the judge to “re-think” social orders and evaluate the affirmative plan in a new light. The research intensive nature of debate facilitates all these processes, and not only requires that students develop a broad base of knowledge about particular policy questions but also teaches them how to obtain knowledge on any policy question that they encounter.

Third, students must be agents of change who are willing to take risks and believe that those actions can make a difference. Ostensibly, the more comfortable students are in participating with the systems that produce change the more willing they will be as risk takers and change agents. Debate teaches students to become agents of change and risk takers because of its competitive, time-pressured, and interscholastic nature. Because debate is competitive, it can be terrifying. Students must engage in a public speaking event, then face the challenges of their opponent, and then immediately receive evaluation by a judge. Students who can face and overcome those challenges and those fears are seldom afraid of public dialogue in any other context, be it a political rally, city board meeting, electoral campaign, legal proceeding, or town hall meeting. The time pressured nature of the activity adds another element of challenge which, when mastered, makes other public discourse seem mundane by comparison. Finally, the interscholastic nature of debate makes students comfortable in dialogues with others of different backgrounds. With UDL support, students from under-served high schools can go to tournaments and compete against students from wealthy school systems. Debate thus addresses at all levels the problems that the under-served confront when approaching institutions so often governed by the graduates of rich, private schools: Skills of discourse are equalized, economic disadvantages become less of a barrier when confronting other rhetors, and the economically under-served gain a conduit to positions of institutional power. The interaction between students from all economic levels can increase understanding and common ground, making it less likely that the governing bodies will represent a single class and will misunderstand others due to a lack of contact. More basically, when students from UDL schools debate against elite high schools and win, the students learn that victory is possible and that economic disadvantages can be overcome. Although there is no single, easy solution to the problem of confronting an institution controlled by someone who “we do not know and whose values we often do not share,” debate at least gives students the experience of comparing ideas with someone from a different socioeconomic level.

Fourth, there is Friere’s (1993) requirement that students take control of their own learning. Rather than relying strictly on the authority figure of the teacher to direct the learning, the students are depending on themselves and each other. As Melissa Wade (1998) writes:

There are certainly trends in education which encourage interactive and dialogic pedagogies, but few are as potent as debate. Teachers and students from many

different schools from across the United States learn from each other as positions are built and evaluated in the laboratory of competition. A contest round reverses the narration pattern of traditional education. The student speaks to the teacher, referencing information that reflects an understanding of concrete knowledge grounded in research. Through the ballot or the oral critique the teacher reacts, refines ideas, and encourages the student, but the basis of their meeting is student driven; the basis uniquely relevant for student experiential education. In this way, students have an authentic learning experience, an experience that does not treat them like an object to be “filled,” but as a person with whom a teacher shares. (pp. 63-4)

This section has thus far focused narrowly on questions of empowerment and how debate might produce empowered people via empowering means. This does not suggest that debate might not also have more traditional benefits, and the work on this topic is worth reviewing briefly. Brand (1997) assesses the possibilities:

Debate promotes strong research and reasoning skills which go beyond most in-class speaking or writing assignments. The time and commitment of debate competitors manifests itself in skills which can be successfully transferred to a variety of professional experiences. Once removed from the competitive debate environment, debaters are more than capable of using effective delivery and other communication skills. Evaluations of debate based on the competitive environment do an injustice to the excellence which the activity promotes. These benefits need to be made evident to others in the discipline. (p. 263)

In a very direct way, many underachieving students, once “gone on debating,” may become better academic performers. In a more indirect way others may choose to meet the debate team’s academic eligibility requirements because they want to keep participating on the squad. Further, the interscholastic model accelerates learning in an exponential way. Interscholastic debate differs from debate in the classroom (sometimes referred to as “debate across the curriculum”). The difference between the two is analogous to the difference between a regular gym class and a school’s basketball team that competes against other schools. The philosophy behind the gym class is that all students will benefit from some exposure to physical fitness; in a similar vein, the idea behind classroom debate is that all students will benefit from an exposure to the basic precepts of argument and debate. The philosophy behind the basketball team is that the very best athletes will excel to vastly

greater levels of development by competing against the very best athletes of other schools. Although most debate teams are more open to widespread participation than most basketball teams, tournament debate offers the students most “gone on” academic debating a chance to sharpen and refine their skills to truly advanced degrees by competing in tournament formats against the best speakers and debaters from other institutions.

Of course, some debate students fail to improve academically but our experience in over two decades of coaching is that at-risk and underachieving students who become interested in debate usually show academic improvement. Unraveling causality is difficult in any education research, however one recent meta-analysis demonstrated that participation in debate is a powerful way to advance critical thinking skills (Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt, & Loudon, 1999). Debate participation may thus have the potential to improve traditional grades and test scores. In a sense, these concerns are ancillary to the central question of empowerment: Debate has benefits as an empowering method of education quite apart from whether it is a tool to raise achievement as narrowly defined by grades and test scores (which may be symptoms of a hierarchical education rather than true measures of student development; e.g., see Sacks, 2000). However, the evidence offered by Allen, Berkowitz, Hunt, and Loudon (1999) suggests that, on balance, debate participation may raise traditional academic achievement as well, and thus result in the more traditional form of empowerment. Galston (1996) noted that better achievement and post-secondary education expands economic opportunities and gives traditionally excluded people more access to institutional power. Although not the focus of this paper, we do not wish to treat this potential as trivial, and agree with Wade (1998) who writes: “Tournament debate has offered profound skills for many who have used them to achieve national leadership roles in government, business, and education, among others. It is only fair that all have access to such a rich experiential education” (pp. 64-5). Offering debate at under-served schools addresses the inequalities that Kozol has identified.

These arguments are theoretical; they cannot speak as powerfully as the voices of those who have experienced both the oppression of an education system failing from a biased distribution of funding and top-down models of education. Ed Lee, who now holds a Master’s degree, worked for an Urban Debate League, and now coaches at the collegiate level, recounts his experience as a debater:

Educated in the public school system of inner-city Atlanta, my high school experience was tragically similar to the one depicted above. My savior, like many

others, was the Atlanta Urban Debate League. It provided the opportunity to question the nefarious rites of passage (prison, drugs, and drinking) that seem to be uniquely debilitating to individuals in the poor urban communities. In enclaves of poverty, there is also an undercurrent of nihilism and negativity that eats away at the soul of the community. Adults are hopeless. Children follow their lead and become hopeless. The solution is to offer people a choice beyond minimum wage or prison. Urban Debate Leagues provide that. Debating delivers a galaxy of alternatives and opportunity for those who are only offered hopelessness and were unnecessary elements of our culture that existed because they (predominantly) go unquestioned. Questioning the very nature of our existence is at the heart of the debate process. I am left wondering what would occur if debate became as compulsory in inner-city educational culture as football and basketball? Imagine graduating from high school each year millions of underprivileged teenagers with the ability to articulate their needs, the needs of others, and the ability to offer solutions. I am convinced that someone would be forced to listen.

Urban debate Leagues offer a pedagogical tool that simultaneously opens the mind to alternatives and empowers students to take control of their lives. Half of the time, students are disseminating information and forming arguments about complex philosophical and political issues. In the other half, they answer the arguments of others. Self-reflexivity is an inherent part of the activity. Debating gives students the ability to articulate the partiality of all critical assessments. Contemporary educational techniques teach one side of the issue and universalize it as the only "truth." Debate forces students to evaluate both sides, and determine their independent contextualized truth. Additionally, unlike the current pedagogy, debate allows everything to be questioned...The ability to question subjectivities presented as the objective truth makes debate uniquely empowering for individuals disenfranchised by the current system. It teaches students to interrogate their own institutionalized neglect and the systemic unhindered oppression of others. It is one of the few venues in which we are able to question authority. (1998, pp. 95-6)

William Baker, active in the New York Urban Debate League, made this additional observation: "The students are reporting grades, watching CNN, and learning, in some cases for the first time, that knowledge is power and debate is the tool for exercising that power" (1998, pp. 70-1).

Debate as a Method for Collective Empowerment

Friere wrote about empowerment as it related to traditional top-down models of education, but it is worth noting that the theme Friere established has been echoed repeatedly in other arenas and especially in critiques of philanthropy. It is not difficult to find authors who believe that outreach efforts fail when the would-be benefactors privilege their own power, ignore the needs of those that they seek to assist, or conceive of “progress” in ways that simply mean conformity to the practices and values of the benefactors (Escobar, 1995, Robinson, 2000; Lancaster, 1999). Attempts at assistance that mutate into cultural privileging often result in disaster. These new forms of colonization and privileging need not be intentional to be nefarious, and as we seek to use debate as a tool to empower the under-served we must be careful not to unintentionally repeat the errors of past outreach. Most importantly, debate outreach must be a two-way street: We cannot expect simply that debate can reach out and change under-served students. We must also expect that the newly-included students will change current models of intercollegiate debate. Contemporary debate practice has served a number of students very well, but its own practice cannot fall outside its dialectical roots: We must critically examine our own current practices with the same vigor we examine the government policies we debate about. Again the lessons of Friere hold true: We cannot claim that debate can be emancipating if debate is practiced in exclusionary, hierarchical ways.

Current debate practice is not without its critics, and this section will attempt to take those criticisms seriously while proceeding with the belief that the criticisms of debate surround the pathologies of its current practice, and not debate per se (Cirlin, 1997; Bile, 2000). Two themes will be developed. First, although it is tempting to think about specific changes in format that might correct the more pathological elements of debate practice (slower speeds, less aggressive styles), we believe that rather than quibble over individual items on a laundry list of reforms, what is most crucial is the standpoint that reform takes. The voices currently dominating discussions about reform are those of debate professionals, and although they provide important perspectives, they represent the voices of those already included. Our community needs to heed the voices of those currently excluded, who are after all in the best position to explain why they feel left out. Second, we will contend that the competitive nature of academic debate, which has been a focus of criticism, has more empowering possibilities than have been imagined thus far.

Critics of competitive debate have challenged contest-oriented rhetoric generally, and some scholars have applied those criticisms to academic debate particularly. Writing about American discourse broadly, Deborah Tannen (1999) makes the case that current rhetoric perpetuates a western tradition that is antagonistic, overly-simplifies the complexity of any proposition, and creates misinformation because focus is shifted from understanding to winning. Consequences of this rhetoric include non-participation and a loss of interest in the “warlike” atmosphere of politics, journalism, and law, and there is concern that the model creates a standard of behavior that can even influence relationship development. Some feminist observers see direct application of these theories to competitive academic debate, and express deep concerns about competition itself (Hobbs et al., 2000; Foss, 2000). Some critics have invited those interested in alternative models of discourse to engage in a variety of revolutionary acts of resistance, including a call to walk away from the competitive debate format and its emphasis on winning (Foss, 2000).

Other criticisms have been directed at the lack of diversity in debate. Loge (1991) maintains that the perception of debate as a white activity is one deterrent for black students. Hill (1997) argues that cultural communication differences hurt efforts at motivating African-American participation. Cirlin (1997) contends that the style in academic debate turns people off in general, and argues that we need to consider sociological approaches to changing the nature of the activity. Cirlin believes that the rapid rate of delivery, the extreme emphasis on research, and the technical nature of the “game” serve to destroy the rhetorical usefulness of the event. However, Brand (1997) argues that criticism over format acts to shield discussions about the benefits of forensic participation.

We agree with each of the authors, and believe that the lack of participation by non-traditional groups is a culmination of the above criticisms that include questions of practice, access, motivation, and poor public relations. Although Cirlin’s (1997) criticisms of debate format might apply equally well to all participants, if Hill (1997) is correct and cultural factors are crucial to the successful recruitment and retention of those from historically oppressed groups, an activity whose style and practice aligns with dominant society may be especially unattractive to those groups. Participation and retention of participants generally, and for historically oppressed groups in particular, is in part a product of their perception of what the game does and whom it benefits. Although it is always unclear how much latitude critics have to make empirical observations, as career debate professionals we get the sense that at present the intercollegiate debate community generally believes that the activity is

structurally satisfactory and the lack of diversity is due to a variety of factors not associated with the culture and norms of the game. We have a different view that we hope to elaborate here and justify in the space that follows. We believe that where those involved in academic debate see space for diversity, non-participants see an activity that replicates institutional modes of domination and this factor, more than any other, lies behind the critiques of current debate practice. More than debating questions of format amongst ourselves we need to adopt a framework that systematically includes the voices of those currently marginalized.

Identity-formation is a product of our competing cultural experiences (Hecht, Collier, & Ribeau, 1993). The more one is assimilated into mainstream or dominant society, the more likely one's value system is to gravitate towards the dominant perspective and away from perspectives associated with the unique experiences of the collectively marginalized. Those outside the mainstream produce a set of collective values that differ from those held by mainstream America. "Those who lack material wealth or political power still have access to thought and language, and their development of those tools will differ from that of the more privileged" (Matsuda, 1987, p. 335).

Matsuda's (1987) method of "looking to the bottom" offers a compelling model for transforming practice. Matsuda notes that there is a long tradition of oppressed people appropriating dominant forms of expression and transforming them, making their very use subversive:

Studying the centuries-old tradition of American black women's poetry reveals, according to Stetson, three major elements: "a compelling quest for identity, a subversive perception of reality, and subterfuge and ambivalence as creative strategies." In poetry, the most concentrated form of language, black women have employed words to criticize and transform existing assumptions. Poetry to black women has never been merely aesthetic. It has, first and foremost, been a tool of social change. Gwendolyn Brooks opened one 1949 sonnet: "First fight. Then fiddle." Black musicians see fiddling as part of the fight. Objecting to the de-transformation of black jazz for white audiences and also to the commodification of black musicians, be-bop artists like Thelonious Monk vowed to "create something they can't steal because they can't play it." Black musicians resist cooption by asserting their moral claim to the jazz form. For the legal theorist, the relevance of the black artist's fight to establish progressive language and music is that the fight

over the body and soul of American law is part of the same struggle. The law, as critical scholars recognize, consists of language, ideals, signs, and structures that have material and moral consequences. Transforming this kind of system into one's own has a long tradition in the black community. (pp. 335-337)

Just as Matsuda (1987) applies the transformative tradition to the practice of law, we believe that the lessons can be applied to academic debate. If offered access to the creative form of debate, new participants can appropriate it and make their very debating a critique of the domination in debate in ways that those sharing a majority worldview cannot imagine on their own.

This approach requires two strands of action and thought. Minorities must first have access to a creative form: African-American musicians could not develop jazz without access to musical training, and poets could not create their prose without literacy. The first section of this article has argued for making the creative form of debate accessible to all. As a second requirement, however, audiences must appreciate these new forms. Debate audiences must be as willing to accept arguments that sound as strange to their ears as the atonal, multi-rhythmic music of Monk must sound to musicians trained to listen to Bach and Mozart. Most crucially, however, debate professionals must recognize that it is the students currently excluded who are in the best position to inform us about the changes in format that need to be made. The crucial point is that reforms in the debate format ought not be controlled by those writing in journals, but by the non-traditional students participating in debate. Matsuda (1987) again makes the point well:

There is a standing concept in movements for social change. One needs to ask who has the real interest and the most information. Those who are oppressed in the present world can speak most eloquently of a better one. Their language will not be abstract, detached or inaccessible; their program will not be undefined. They will advance clear ideas about the next step to a better world. The experience of struggling against racism has taught much about struggle, about how real people can rise up, look power in the eye and turn it around. (p. 346)

Our call is for debate professionals to listen to the new arguments and styles of new participants, and allow their voices to lead us to a new rhetoric for academic debate. We can either discuss among ourselves what elements of debate style make it such a white-dominated activity, or we can listen to the unique styles and expressions of new-found

debaters and validate them with positive feedback. We can use our ballots to affirm new styles of debate.

Just as critiques of development projects call for consideration of recipient-driven models as opposed to current (and failing) donor-driven ones, the need for the debate community to become less “debate-professional centered” when evaluating itself seems like an important first step in challenging the domination-centered model of debate. The elitist and unidirectional conception of debate outreach as an act of benevolence which will help the marginalized overcome “their” condition ignores the reality that those left out of “mainstream” debate practice are critically important to helping the debate community to overcome “their” condition as well. Recognition that those structures in interscholastic debate may need challenging and that diversity needs to occur as much for current participants as for potential ones will be the largest hurdle that the interscholastic debate community faces if the evolution of the activity is to resist and challenge rather than create and perpetuate Tannen’s (1999) “argument culture.”

The second theme this section will address involves competition. One view, of course, is that competition is innately bad, that it creates divisiveness, and that it divides communities. We, however, believe in a more nuanced view, and at least three points argue against an *a priori* rejection of competition. First, competition and the tournament format can create dialogues that would never take place otherwise. Debate tournaments are places where many cultures, socio-economic backgrounds, and styles engage one another in the “game” of debate. Similar to other activities, involvement by diverse cultures creates some measure of integration. Debate goes beyond simple contact, however, and offers the opportunity for the evaluation of diverse voices discussing a similar topic. The negotiation between traditional “policy wonk” perspectives and, for example, radical feminist arguments, is an interaction that occurs in few venues. Different perspectives and ideologies come to the table and real interaction occurs in an immediate way. One positive function of competition is that it serves as a motivational starting point for interaction. People who would not otherwise meet come together, and conversations that would not otherwise occur become real.

Secondly, empirical evidence suggests that individuals with well developed argument skills (as opposed to the shrill nay saying tendencies Tannen (1999) objects to) are actually more empathic, less ego-centric, and better at taking the perspective of others than are those less adept at arguing well (Infante, Rancer, & Womack, 1990). Rather than create

divisiveness, there is some reason to believe that the argumentativeness engendered by competition may actually increase empathy. This is not a counter-intuitive finding or strange by-product of a fundamentally destructive activity, but is exactly the sort of outcome one would expect from a truly dialectical thinker (Billig, 1987). An anecdote offered by one of the authors of this paper might further illustrate the point. As a white male professor teaching argumentation, a point I often make while de-briefing class debates is that more content is absorbed by debating a topic rather than writing a paper about it. At the conclusion of one of the debates in my class I asked my students whether any of them had changed their mind about the topic, expecting that a few would. Nobody in the class had changed their mind, but to a person every student felt that they better understood and sympathized with opinions that were not their own. The topic was mandatory vaccinations, and one student commented: "Before, I would have thought that anybody who didn't want to have their kids vaccinated was a freak. Now I can see that they definitely have a point, and I think I understand where they're coming from better." Of course, this is only the experience of one class, but I believe that the point is fairly general and illustrates how the competitive nature of academic debate – challenging each student to find the best available case for any given point of view and asking them to switch sides – has powerful potential to make students more empathetic with different points of view. Importantly, these benefits came about because of the competition and not in spite of it. Students absorbed more content than they would have by writing a paper because they knew their ideas would be challenged, and they became more empathetic because they switched sides. It is difficult to imagine these benefits accruing without a competitive tournament format.

Third, we believe that the competition has a special ability to motivate otherwise unmotivated students, and especially African-American males. We offer an anecdote from the other author of this paper that we hope will illustrate our point. As an African-American professor who coaches a collegiate squad with a special emphasis on recruiting African-Americans, I have observed a pattern in the course of instructing new students. Majors (1992) argues that African American males demonstrate a "Cool Pose" (read: disinterest and apathy) to resist institutions and activities of the dominant society, which in part is a coping strategy against historical oppression. Majors contends that African-American males, as early as elementary school, begin to see education as a white-dominated institution, and adopt a Cool Pose toward learning, resisting the whiteness with disinterest. Debate can easily be perceived as an extension of the white educational institution; Hill (1997) has

noted that participation often requires assimilation or “acting white.” When trying to recruit a new group of students this year, I noticed that the males in our group showed little interest in learning debate, which I taught in a traditional classroom way. They were adopting the traditional Cool Pose toward education. When the competition began and we went to our first tournament, and especially when our African American women demonstrated success, the African American males became substantially more involved. Of course, everyone reacts differently, but I generally believe that the males in our group became motivated about debate only when they were “gone on” the competition.

What is to be made of these conclusions in light of the criticisms of others? What conclusions can be made about competition? One instinct is to try to make a totalizing judgment and decide that competition is either good or bad. Another possibility is to notice that competition might be both good and bad: It might motivate some students while excluding others. The most interesting possibility is that competition is not good or bad, not good for some and bad for others, but good in some ways (when used well) and bad in other ways (when used to excess). How can the beneficial elements of competition be retained while the pathological facets of it eliminated? To some extent, of course, coaches and judges can and should serve as mentors who constantly advise students to guard against becoming too competitive and correct them when they cross the line. We must constantly remind our students that they must “use wins and losses, don’t let them use you.”

Another, and possibly more powerful strategy, is to simply allow the voices of non-traditional participants to serve as a correction and critique of the excesses of competition. One unique feature of oppressed voices is their duality, their ability to resist oppression while engaging in activities that have created domination. We quote Matsuda (1987) a final time:

The dissonance of combining deep criticism of law with an aspirational vision of law is part of the experience of people of color. These people have used duality as a strength, and have developed strategies for resolving this dissonance through the process of appropriation and transformation. W.E.B. DuBois noted long ago the resiliency of the consciousness of “Black Folk.” The consciousness he described includes both mainstream American consciousness, and the consciousness of the outsider. Applying the double consciousness concept to rights rhetoric allows us to see that the victim of racism can have a mainstream consciousness of the Bill of Rights, as well as a victim’s consciousness. These two viewpoints can combine

powerfully to create a radical constitutionalism that is true to the radical roots of this country. The strands of republicanism that legal historians are reviving with the feather-brush care of an archeologist are alive and well in the constitutional discourse of non-white America. (pp. 333-334)

It would be horrible indeed if groups of victims were pitted against one another – if those for whom competition was a benefit progressed at the expense of those for whom competition has been a hindrance. If, however, the voices of the excluded are taken seriously, those participants in debate who find themselves injured by its competitive nature can incorporate their own duality into their own debate practice: They can find ways of debating that express resistance to the excesses of competition. Already, the top levels of college debate have seen competitors resisting the objective nature of debate by introducing emotion, resisting the uni-dimensional view that evidence can only come from experts by introducing narratives, and resisting the extreme emphasis on speed by introducing fewer arguments and making a conscious effort to speak more slowly. In short, it may be a false distinction to suggest that debate must either be competitive or inclusive – the unique duality of oppressed voices suggest that competitors can simultaneously engage in competition and resist the excesses of it. All that is necessary is for the debate community to create space for those voices.

Conclusion

This essay has taken on two challenges. First, it has explored the possibilities of debate as a tool of empowerment by theorizing what empowerment means and exploring how debate might facilitate that conception of empowerment. The project comes at a poignant time, as debate outreach is proceeding quickly with empowerment as a goal even as conceptions of empowerment remain fuzzy. We conclude that debate can help students become critical consumers of knowledge, social critics, and agents of change, while also developing traditional academic skills. Second, this essay has explored questions of format and how it might be altered to maximize inclusion. We imagine a response that embraces the criticisms other theorists have offered and attempts to use them to suggest alternative practices. We believe that questions of format are best addressed by “looking to the bottom.” Debate professionals should discover from the excluded themselves why they avoid debate, and should take unique styles and argument forms seriously. By listening to those voices we can help debate become for others the tool of empowerment it was for

Malcolm X – a vehicle to confront oppression, an activity brave enough to recognize its own disempowering aspects. Debate is an empowering activity but it can be made better. Debate cannot remain empowering if it remains static. If we want our students to be critics of knowledge and agents of change, we must trust our activity enough to allow it to become the object of criticism and to be susceptible to change.

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